

DIPLOMATIC WORKING DOCUMENT — MODULAR ANNEX

Annex PC

Political Assurance & Cooling-Off Protocol

*A time-limited, no-penalty Political Stability Hold for transitions of government —
preserving core obligations while giving new administrations a built-in review period*

Modular · Self-Contained · Incorporable by Reference

Version 1.0 – June 2026 | Bridging Protocol Series

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Preamble

The Parties recognize that changes in administration, elections, or domestic political crises may create sudden pressure to repudiate or withdraw from this MOU, even when no underlying compliance violation exists. Such politically driven withdrawal risks destabilizing the framework without giving the new administration time to assess the agreement's benefits.

This Annex establishes a Political Stability Hold — a time-limited, no-penalty pause in the implementation of non-core obligations triggered by a verified change in government or a major domestic political crisis. The Hold preserves the core nuclear, maritime, and humanitarian obligations while giving the new administration a built-in cooling-off period to review the agreement before deciding whether to withdraw.

This Annex does not eliminate or extend the withdrawal notice period under MOU Article 8.5. It creates an optional pause that, if invoked, suspends only the clock for non-core reciprocal steps. Withdrawal remains possible at any time, but the Hold reduces the perceived need for immediate, disruptive action.

Modularity Clause

This Annex is self-contained and incorporable by a single sentence of adoption. In the event of inconsistency, the parent MOU governs the withdrawal right; this Annex governs the Political Stability Hold procedure.

Article 1 — Definitions

"Political Stability Hold" means a temporary, unilateral pause in the implementation of non-core obligations (economic relief tranches other than humanitarian, military de-escalation steps other than those protecting core freedoms, and regional stabilization activities) for a period of up to 60 days, triggered by a qualifying political event.

"Qualifying Political Event"

A Qualifying Political Event means any of the following occurring in either Party's country:

- (1) A general election that results in a change of the head of government or head of state;

(2) The inauguration of a new president or prime minister following an election;

(3) A constitutional succession (e.g., new Supreme Leader in Iran);

(4) A formal declaration by the head of state or head of government of the Party that the Party does not consider the MOU binding on the new administration, pending review, provided that such declaration is communicated in writing to the PCC Secretariat and the other Party;

(5) A large-scale domestic political crisis that materially disrupts the ordinary functioning of the executive branch (e.g., mass protests leading to a state of emergency, cabinet collapse, or a successful no-confidence vote), as verified by the PCC upon request of either Party, based on a factual assessment provided by the JMC (Annex Mo) within 48 hours of the request. If the PCC cannot reach consensus within 72 hours, the Deputy Convenor (Pakistan) issues a neutral factual determination, which serves as the verification for purposes of this subparagraph.

"Core Obligations"

The following continue in full force during any Political Stability Hold:

Obligation	Source
Enrichment cap at 3.67%	MOU Article 3.1
IAEA dual-key custody of HEU	Annex Y
Freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz	MOU Article 4.1
Non-interdiction protocol	Annex N
Humanitarian firewall and humanitarian escrow releases	MOU Article 5.4; Annex T
IAEA access rights	Annex O
Escalation buffer and back-channel	Annexes R, R.a

"Non-Core Obligations"

All obligations not listed as Core, including but not limited to: scheduled frozen-asset tranches (except humanitarian), SWIFT reconnection beyond the humanitarian minimum, oil-export normalization beyond baseline levels, military stand-off adjustments, and regional stabilization round attendance.

Article 2 — Invocation of Political Stability Hold

2.1 Eligibility

A Party invokes the Hold only within 30 days after the Qualifying Political Event occurs. The invocation is in writing to the PCC Secretariat and the other Party, specifying the event and the anticipated duration (up to 60 days).

2.2 Automatic Hold

Upon invocation, the Hold activates immediately. The invoking Party is not required to prove any compliance failure by the other Party.

2.3 Effect on Core Obligations

Core Obligations continue unchanged. Any failure to perform a Core Obligation during the Hold is treated as a normal compliance matter under MOU Article 7.3 and Annex T.

2.4 Effect on Non-Core Obligations

During the Hold, the invoking Party's own non-core obligations are suspended. The other Party's corresponding non-core obligations are also suspended reciprocally, unless the other Party elects in writing to continue them voluntarily. No suspension constitutes a breach or triggers step-back.

2.5 Duration

The Hold expires automatically after 60 days unless the invoking Party withdraws the Hold earlier by written notice. A single 30-day extension is available if the invoking Party certifies that the political crisis continues and notifies the PCC.

2.6 Maximum Hold

No more than 90 consecutive days per Qualifying Political Event. No more than two Holds per Party per 365-day period.

Article 3 — Effect on Withdrawal Clock

3.1 Withdrawal Notice Unaffected

A Party gives notice of withdrawal under MOU Article 8.5 (30-day clean break) at any time, including during a Hold. The Hold does not extend the 30-day withdrawal period.

3.2 Political Reassurance

If a new administration invokes the Hold, it commits to conducting a good-faith review of the MOU during the Hold period. The PCC provides briefings and access to verification data to facilitate that review.

3.3 No Penalty for Non-Invocation

A Party that does not invoke the Hold following a Qualifying Political Event waives no rights and may still invoke the Hold for a subsequent event.

Article 4 — Safeguards Against Abuse

4.1 No Serial Invocation

A Party may not invoke a second Hold for the same Qualifying Political Event after the first expires. A new election or succession qualifies as a new event.

4.2 Good Faith Requirement

Invocation without a genuine Qualifying Political Event, or invocation solely to avoid performance of non-core obligations without a political transition, constitutes a Tier 2 Material Disruption under Annex T.

4.3 PCC Review

The PCC may determine that an invocation lacks a good-faith basis. Such a determination requires a vote of the PCC excluding the invoking Party (i.e., consensus of the remaining members). If the remaining members agree by simple majority (or unanimously if the remaining membership is evenly split), the Hold terminates immediately and all obligations are restored. The invoking Party may not block termination under this paragraph.

Article 5 — Relationship to Other Annexes

Annex / Provision	Relationship
Annex IC (Institutional Continuity)	Annex IC binds the state; this Annex provides a transitional pause for a new administration, not a permanent escape.
Annex T (Step-Back / Earn-Back)	No step-back applies during a properly invoked Hold. Abuse of the Hold triggers Tier 2.
MOU Article 8.5 (Withdrawal)	Withdrawal notice remains available. The Hold does not extend the notice period.
Annex R.b (Narrative Dispute)	A Party may not use the Hold as a narrative to claim the other Party breached the MOU.

Article 6 — Incorporation by Reference

This Annex PC is incorporable into any existing or future agreement through the following adoption sentence:

"The Parties adopt Annex PC (Political Assurance and Cooling-Off Protocol) as an operative provision of this Agreement. This Annex provides a time-limited, no-penalty Political Stability Hold following a qualifying change in government or domestic political crisis, preserving core obligations while allowing a new administration a good-faith review period."

No amendment of the parent MOU is required. This Annex enters into force upon signature by both Parties or provisional application by exchange of diplomatic notes.

Signature Block

The undersigned, duly authorized, adopt this Annex PC (Political Assurance and Cooling-Off Protocol) as an operative provision binding upon their respective Parties.

Done at _____, this ____ day of _____, 2026, in duplicate in the English language.

For the Islamic Republic of Iran	For the United States of America
Signature: _____	Signature: _____
Name / Title: _____	Name / Title: _____
Date: _____	Date: _____

Noted by the PCC Secretariat (Geneva)

Representative: _____ Date: _____

Design Rationale

Why This Reduces Political Fragility

A new administration does not have to immediately repudiate the deal. It can invoke a 60-day pause on non-core obligations while keeping the nuclear and maritime cores intact — a politically defensible "time to review" rather than a rash "tear it up."

- Core verification and non-proliferation benefits continue, so the international community does not panic.
- The other Party's corresponding non-core obligations also pause, so no Party suffers unilateral disadvantage.
- Withdrawal remains possible, but the Hold creates a default path of less resistance — review first, decide later.
- The built-in abuse safeguards prevent cynical use to stall indefinitely.

This annex directly addresses the fear that a new U.S. president (or a new Iranian leadership) will face immediate pressure to walk away. Now they have a graceful, pre-approved "timeout" button.